Excerpt from “Self-Reliance”

Ralph Waldo Emerson | Worksheet answers

1. Paraphrase the underlined metaphor.

Just as a farmer must work the land to grow food, a person must develop their own abilities through effort to gain something valuable from life. The “plot of ground” represents the abilities and circumstances a person has been given, and the corn represents the rewards of using them.

2. Restate the first paragraph’s main idea. Do you agree?

Emerson’s main idea is that people should accept themselves, trust their unique abilities, and put their full effort into their work instead of envying or copying others. People discover what they can do by trying, and sincere effort gives them satisfaction. I agree because constantly comparing ourselves to others can keep us from developing our own strengths. Learning from someone else is useful, but copying their life does not help us discover what we can contribute ourselves.

3. What metaphors appear in the underlined lines? How are they effective?

In “every heart vibrates to that iron string,” Emerson compares self-trust to a strong musical string and the human heart to an instrument responding to it. The image suggests that self-trust is a firm inner force that people naturally respond to. In “noble clay, plastic under the Almighty effort,” he compares people to moldable clay and God to the force shaping it. This makes spiritual growth easier to picture: people have value and potential, but they must be willing to develop. Together, the metaphors connect confidence in ourselves with openness to growth.

4. Summarize the second paragraph. Do you agree? What are “chaos” and “the dark”?

Emerson urges people to trust themselves, accept their place in the world, and face the future bravely while allowing God to shape them. “Chaos” represents disorder and confusion, while “the dark” represents the unknown and what people do not yet understand. I agree that uncertainty should not stop people from acting. For example, someone starting a difficult project cannot know every outcome beforehand, but working through unfamiliar problems gives them a chance to grow.

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5. Explain the joint-stock company metaphor. What does a person give up? Do you agree?

Emerson compares society to a company whose shareholders receive material security in exchange for giving something up. The “bread” represents basic needs and comfort. To secure these benefits, people surrender some freedom, independent judgment, and personal development by conforming to society’s expectations. I partly agree because pressure to fit in can make people hide their beliefs or follow a path they do not want. However, cooperation does not always destroy individuality. People can share responsibilities and follow fair rules while still thinking for themselves.

6. Summarize Emerson’s main point in this section.

Society rewards conformity and often values familiar customs more than original ideas or the people who create them. Emerson argues that a person must resist this pressure and protect the integrity of their own mind. Being true to one’s judgment matters more than gaining approval by agreeing with everyone else.

7. Explain “To be great is to be misunderstood.” Why reject consistency? Is this wise or impractical?

Emerson means that people with original ideas often challenge familiar beliefs, so others may misunderstand them. His examples of influential thinkers show why misunderstanding should not automatically make someone abandon an idea. He rejects “foolish consistency,” meaning the refusal to change a belief just to match what one said before. I think this is wise when new evidence or deeper understanding gives someone a reason to change. However, changing opinions carelessly would make a person unreliable. The goal should be honest growth, while still explaining changes and taking responsibility for commitments.